The Days Around Mom's Discharge

What to do, in order, to get ready for the care conversation: ten actions, each with a line for who and by when.

The goal: when you talk with the discharge planner, the care team or your Medicaid planner, you have a clear, dated picture of what changed, where Mom needs help today, what you've been told, and which questions are still open.

Share the list. Put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Write down why Mom went into the hospital and what changed, in your own words.			
2. Gather what you've been handed so far: discharge papers, her diagnoses as they were given to you, the current medication list.			
3. Note what you've seen Mom do this week and where the staff help: bathing, dressing, eating, using the toilet, getting in and out of bed, walking.			
4. Write down what you've noticed about her memory and about how she manages when no one is with her, as what you saw.			
5. List the parts of her day you haven't seen, and any safety concern you want someone to look at. Ask a nurse or a therapist about each.			
6. List your medication questions for the nurse, the doctor or the pharmacist. Change nothing.			
7. Ask the discharge planner for the expected discharge date and for the discharge plan in writing.			
8. Ask whether Medicare is covering Mom's care now, and whether and when that may change. Write down who told you, and on which day.			
9. Write down who is making healthcare decisions with Mom or for her, and which family members can help, and with what.			
10. Put every open question on one list. Next to each, write who it goes to: the discharge planner, the doctor or a nurse, the business office, or your Medicaid planner.			

You're done when

What changed, where Mom needs help today, what you've been told and by whom, and the dates you've been given are all written down, and every open question has a name beside it, including the ones about what care she needs, where it can be provided, what it may cost and which decision comes next. Answering those questions, and any decision about where Mom goes or how her care is paid for, isn't on this list, because it isn't the family's to do alone.

If the days don't go in order

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “We don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If a date changes, or you're told something you don't follow, write down who said it and ask the discharge planner to go over it with you.
- If something about how Mom is doing worries you, tell her nurse or doctor then. This list can wait.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your part. It doesn't certify that Mom is safe to go home, decide what care she needs or where, or stand in for the professionals it prepares you to talk with. Nothing here is medical, legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've done your part, in order, and you know which questions are still open. The care interview goes through Mom's situation with you one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to your Medicaid planner and to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›